



CLUELESS: A monkey walks into a trap in a Delhi park

Tribal Cure for Simian Terror

Local authorities get tough on the capital's monkeys using tribal catchers from Madurai

■ By Shyamlal Yadav

They sit a hundred metres away, a thin wire in their hands ready to be pulled at any instant. A small triangular cage sits in the ridge near Delhi University, innocuous yet out of place with the lush greenery surrounding it. A monkey, drawn to the strange object, ignores the signs and makes its way into the cage when the gate slams shut. That's one down, 19,999 more to go for R. Ramnathan, a contractor from Madurai who has been entrusted with the responsibility of ridding the capital of its monkeys. Says Ramnathan, "We have a target of capturing 20,000 monkeys in a year. More teams will be arriving from Madurai after Deepawali."



The primates have suddenly become a target for local authorities following the outcry over the demise, on October 21, of the city's deputy mayor S.S. Bajwa, who fell from the balcony of his house fending off a pack of monkeys. The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has set a budget of Rs 1 crore to tackle this nuisance and is awarding catchers Rs 450 for every monkey trapped. The captured primates are handed over to a monkey shelter in the Bhatti Mines area in the south of Delhi. Says an MCD veterinary officer at Civil Lines—one of 12 MCD zones in Delhi—

"My zone is one of the worst affected. But with the help of these catchers we will definitely eliminate this menace."

Ramnathan's team is considered one of the most successful in Delhi. They have been in the capital for nearly a month and have caged over 360 monkeys. Most of the other teams use primates like langurs to threaten the monkeys, basically exploiting the fear factor. But this technique doesn't work all the time since not all monkeys are afraid of langurs. Relying on this technique can also be dangerous as one langur-assisted catcher Mohammad Akram was badly injured last year, and had to be sewn up with 72 stitches. Ramnathan's teams consist of tribals of the Malaikorvan community in Madurai, who have developed ways of trapping monkeys harmlessly. His team has eight members, all from a single family, who get paid Rs 200 every day.

Along with this exercise, the local authorities are also punishing people who feed the monkeys, usually out of reverence for the monkey-God Hanuman. MCD, which administers over 96 per cent of the capital's area, has had no infrastructure in place to deal with this nuisance as there are no related provisions in the MCD Act. But their problem has now become the tribals' gain as they get serious with monkey business.